

Proposal for Educational Excursion

Jamie Gabriel, Music Teacher (Stage 4/5)

Excursion Title:

Sydney Symphony Orchestra – Daytime Schools Concert at the Sydney Opera House

Target Group:

Year 9–10 Elective Music Students (Stage 5)

Date/Duration:

One school day (approx. 7 a.m.– 6 p.m.) during Term 3

Venue:

Sydney Opera House, Concert Hall

Overview:

On this excursion, students will attend a live Sydney Symphony Orchestra performance, providing them with a unique opportunity to engage directly with professional musicians in an authentic concert setting. During the excursion, students will observe orchestral techniques, ensemble coordination, and performance choices firsthand. They will take notes on elements that relate to their classroom learning in composing, performing, and listening. They will actively analyse the music they hear, identify instrumentation and timbre, and reflect on how musical ideas are developed and communicated. Students will also participate in guided pre and post concert activities, such as discussions and listening tasks. This will further deepen their understanding and connect the live experience to their own creative work.

Related syllabus outcomes

The NSW *Years 7–10 Music Syllabus* emphasises composing, performing, and listening as interrelated experiences and key outcomes are listed below. Note that some year 8 students have expressed interest in attending and related outcomes are for both stages 4 and 5 are included.

Stage	Outcomes	Connection to Excursion
Stage 4	4.6, 4.7, 4.8	Students identify and analyse how orchestral music uses concepts of music (tone colour, dynamics, texture, structure).
Stage 5	5.5, 5.7, 5.8	Students evaluate and explain the impact of live performance and orchestration on audience experience; extend aural discrimination skills.

Relevant content areas

- **Listening:** Students will be able to hear live orchestral repertoire from different periods (e.g. Romantic and 20th-century, relating to in class work) and also hear different parts of the orchestra in solo and in ensemble settings.
- **Performing/Composing:** Students will gain insight into ensemble balance, dynamics, and students will have an opportunity to apply this in class compositions or ensemble work.

Educational Goals

This excursion has been designed so students can:

- Deepen their understanding of orchestration, timbre, large-ensemble interaction, conduction and large scale music forms.
- Develop their aesthetic appreciation and critical listening skills through direct exposure to professional performance.
- Provide an authentic context that students can draw on during later classroom composition and analysis tasks.

Benefits of student learning in this context

The ability of students to experience authentic performance and arts environments improves engagement, motivation, and higher-order thinking. This is supported by the following evidence:

- Kolb's Experiential Learning Theory, which highlights the importance of concrete experience as a catalyst for reflective observation and abstract conceptualisation (Kolb, 2015).
- Live music exposure has been demonstrated to enhance aural development and long-term/lifelong engagement with music education (Coffman & Adamek, 2019).
- Place-based learning has been demonstrated to strengthen cultural appreciation and understanding, and will broaden students' understanding of the professional arts in Australia (Gruenewald & Smith, 2014).
- Arts based excursions have been shown to increase intrinsic motivation and social connection, particularly for adolescents (Garvis & Pendergast, 2017).

These findings demonstrate that a live symphonic performance can create learning outcomes that are not replicable in a classroom or through recordings alone.

Logistics

- **Travel:** Chartered coach, departing school 8 a.m., returning ~4 p.m.
- **Supervision Ratio:** 1:15 staff-student ratio in line with NSW DoE guidelines.
- **Cost Estimate:** \$25 student ticket + \$20 transport = \$45 per student.
- **Pre- and Post-Activities:**
 - Pre-visit lessons on orchestral families and set repertoire.
 - Post-visit reflective listening journal and small-group composition using observed orchestration techniques.

References

- Coffman, D., & Adamek, M. (2019). *The impact of live performance on adolescent music learning*. *Journal of Research in Music Education*, 67(3), 245-260.
- Garvis, S., & Pendergast, D. (2017). *Student engagement in arts-rich learning environments*. *Australian Journal of Education*, 61(1), 60-72.
- Gruenewald, D. A., & Smith, G. A. (2014). *Place-based education in the global age*. Routledge.

- Kolb, D. A. (2015). *Experiential learning: Experience as the source of learning and development* (2nd ed.). Pearson.
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